



IN THE CLOUDS The Nilgiri tahr and (below) Great Hornbill pictured by director Sandesh Kadur in his film

DOCUMENTARY ▼

AMONG THE BLUE MOUNTAINS

The award-winning film *Nilgiris—A Shared Wilderness* has been wowing audiences across India. We find out why...

The Nilgiris, southern India's majestic blue mountains spanning Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Kerala, are said to be among the oldest in the world. It's in this almost-mystical ecosystem that the film *Nilgiris—A Shared Wilderness* was conceptualised and created. The feature-length film—released in cinemas across India in mid-July—brings to life the trials and triumphs of wildlife in the Nilgiris like few have witnessed. Director Sandesh Kadur, founder, Felis Creations, says, "While it's hard getting space and attention for a wildlife film in a country flooded by mainstream cinema, bringing wildlife stories to the mainstream is incredibly important." Executive producer Rohini Nilekani, who has deep ties to the Nilgiris, agrees. A conversation between her, her husband Nandan Nilekani, and Kadur about the lack of full-length documentaries on the Nilgiris while walking in the forests of Coonoor a few years ago sparked the idea to make the film.

"Roughly 80 to 90 per cent of the Nilgiris has been transformed by human use. At first glance, you might wonder if any wild animals remain. But look closely, and you'll find gaur, leopards, black panthers, sambhar deer, barking deer... all quietly sharing space with humans. It's the tolerance of local communities that makes this coexistence possible. Tea estate workers come in, animals move away. As soon as they leave, the animals return. It's an elegant ebb and flow," says Kadur. Supported by Dheeraj Films, the team felt they could push the boundaries of distribution. "Our goal was to go beyond the usual cities. In just the first weekend, we were able to screen it to 20,000 people across the country. We're exploring an OTT release and translations into regional languages."

"WE WOULD WAIT AT A LOCATION FOR **SEVERAL DAYS JUST TO GET ONE SHOT,"** SAYS DIRECTOR SANDESH KADUR

Nilgiris took about three years to complete, with over 500 hours of raw footage shot on Sony's top-tier gear—including the Burano, FX3 and their mirrorless systems. They also used RED cameras and a range of DJI drones to capture both sweeping landscapes and intimate wildlife moments. It was a labour of love. "We were going to the same location or waiting for that one shot for several days. We waited 70–80 days to get just one sequence of a hornbill chick fledging," says Kadur. It truly took a 'mountain of people' to make this film.

It's taken immense effort to shine a light on a region that is both deeply familiar and yet, in many ways, overlooked. "Stirring a sense of awe in the next generation is a key goal. Awe is what creates love. And if you can stir that emotion, it could lead to action," says Kadur, offering a ray of hope. ■

—Priya Pathiyan